

OTTO THE ROBOT

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INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

A room with a large window overlooking a parking lot in front of a large production hall. A table stands next to the door, and across from it, against the opposite wall, is a shelf with folders in the bottom.

OTTO sits at his table, tinkering away at an experimental looking gadget with a wild array of hardware pieces, cables, screws and bolts.

Next to him stands a box labeled "Broken Parts".

Otto is completely lost in his task and doesn't notice TYPEFACE knocking and entering his office.

Upon seeing what Otto is doing, Typeface explodes into an angry rant.

TYPEFACE
WHAT ON EARTH ARE YOU DOING?

Otto jumps up in his seat and spins around, eyes wide open.

OTTO
(startled)
Oh! Woah, I didn't notice you there,
sorry!

TYPEFACE
(huffing)
Well that should hardly make a
difference. You are wasting
resources!

OTTO
Oh, no, these pieces were
manufacturing defects. I'm trying
to see if they can be turned into
something useful.

TYPEFACE
Those are pieces of trash! It's bad
enough that they are defects, but
YOU are FURTHER wasting time and
money that should be going into the
FACTORY'S operations management!

Suddenly a huge crash can be heard.

Typeface and Otto both look up surprised and stare out the window for a moment, before Typeface races out of the room. 1

EXT. FACTORY GROUNDS - DAY

Factory production hall.

Typeface speeds into the production hall. After a moment he comes back out again, yelling into a phone.

TYPEFACE

(enraged)

"We need the external Repair Service
NOW! All production has come to a
stop!"

INT. VAN - DAY

A van driving towards the Factory.

BEX, a robot who looks remarkably similar to Otto, drives the van.

The dashboard is covered in sticky notes with various information on it like "Current Jobs" "Still to do" "Successful Rescues" "Difficult Jobs" and a little plant in a dashboard-flowerpot.

Bex is on a call with KATIE. The phone screen shows her sitting in front of shelves overflowing with cables and monitors.

BEX

Yes, but I got a great opportunity
this morning, a call came in from
the FACTORY! A chance like this
doesn't come around often.

KATIE

I know, but it might be dangerous.

BEX

But if there's a chance to contact
him, I gotta at least try! I
haven't seen him since the
Botanical Garden was taken over.

KATIE

But the FACTORY is a very strict
place! Take care of yourself and
hopefully they won't discover your
missing chip. And fill me in how it
went as soon as you can.

BEX
I always do. Almost there now,
gotta clean up in here. See ya next
week!

Bex, looking slightly nervous, starts to remove the sticky notes and plant from the dashboard with one hand whilst driving.

The van reaches the gate of the Factory, which after a moment slowly start to open.

Bex gulps, takes a deep breath and then plasters a huge, fake smile on their face before driving through the now opened gate, onto Factory grounds.

EXT. FACTORY GROUNDS / PARKING LOT - DAY

Parking lot in front of the production hall.

Bex is standing next to the van and starts walking towards the Factory production hall.

Typeface emerges from the door to the hall and approaches Bex.

TYPEFACE:
(impatiently)
Ah, the repair service, you're finally here. Our conveyor system needs to be fixed immediately. It is halting up our output. Time is money!

BEX
Yessir! No problem! It will be done immediately, don't you worry. I also received a report about a not fully efficient robot. If you want, I can have a look.

TYPEFACE
That was quick reporting. Perfect. Yes if you could.

BEX
Should I start there? It would be the most effective way about it, in case that could have consequences in other areas of the FACTORY.

TYPEFACE
(aghast)
Oh! Yes, right this way. And then the production hall. The FACTORY can't lose time!

INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

Otto is sitting at his desk, looking out the window. The box labeled Broken Parts is now standing atop the shelf on the opposite wall with the gadget next to it. Otto sees a van parking up, and Bex getting out of it.

Otto gasps and jumps out of his chair. Surprised he looks down at himself, then back out the window at the other robot. Then back at himself, and back to the robot in the parking lot again.

Through the window Otto sees the robot being met by Typeface, before going towards the office building, out of sight. Otto remains standing looking out the window, lost in thought.

Suddenly there is a knock on the door, it opens a crack, and Bex cautiously peers into the room. Surprised Otto whirls around. Noticing it is the robot that looks so similar to him, Otto gestures for Bex to enter.

BEX

Hello OTTO! I hope I'm not interrupting you. I wanted to come say hello. I'm BEX; pronouns they/them.

OTTO

Hi! Come in! I just saw you from the window.

(pause)

How do you know who I am?

Otto's face gets a slightly concerned look. Bex looks slightly surprised at hearing the question.

BEX

Of course I know where my fellow botanist robots are!

OTTO

(confused and not sure if he's happy about it)

Ehm botanist robots... what?

BEX

Ah. I guess the Factory has locked up some of your memories. That's of course a bit unfortunate. But if you want, I can fill you in a bit? We don't have much time though, I told TYPEFACE I'd be checking you for inefficiencies.

OTTO
(cautiously curious yet
slightly annoyed)
Yes, please! And no, I'm operating
just fine, but there had been a
disagreement on definitions of
efficiency.

BEX
(with a slight nod)
Well, the short of it is that the
robot series you and I belong to
had been produced for the largest
botanical garden that used to be
around here. We gave tours for
visitors, especially young ones,
introducing them to the world of
botany and agromechatronics.

Bex looks at Otto, who in turn is just looking at Bex with
big eyes, not saying a thing.

BEX (CONT'D)
(shrugs and continues)
Eventually, however, the botanical
garden was bought up by the corporate
overlord behind this FACTORY here, and
all assets and employees were sold
off.

At this Otto interrupts Bex.

OTTO
What do you mean? That's illegal!

BEX
Not the human ones, the robot ones.

OTTO
But aren't we part of the stock?

BEX
Oh dear. I see the Factory truly does
brainwash their employees. Aren't we
curious, thinking and feeling beings?
We're employees just like all the
others.

Otto thinks about this for a bit, then slowly gives a small nod.

OTTO
...maybe?

A bit exasperated, Bex looks around the room and discovers Otto's gadget on the shelf, next to the box labeled Broken Parts. Otto notices Bex's gaze falling onto the gadget. Quickly he speeds over to it and hastily puts it into the compartment in the chest of his chassis.

OTTO (CONT'D)

That's nothing, just a piece of old junk!

BEX

(with an encouraging smile)

It looked interesting. May I see it?

Otto hesitates, looks at the door, then at Bex.

OTTO

(nervously)

I... I guess. But it's just junk.
Manufacturing defects.

Otto takes out the gadget again and slowly hands it to Bex.

BEX

If it were junk, why'd you put it into
your compartment?

Otto looks from Bex to the gadget and back again, then shrugs.
Bex meanwhile continues to inspect the gadget.

BEX (CONT'D)

This is great! A very intuitive way of
re-purposing parts. It reminds me of
my friends. Any idea what it'll be?

Otto looks at Bex, shrugs and shakes his head. After turning it over and over, looking at it from every side, Bex places the gadget back on the shelf.

BEX (CONT'D)

Do you know of the Hacker Community?

OTTO

(after a small pause)

No, I don't think so... What's that?

BEX

It's a group of people, similarly
curious to you. They want to learn
about things, re-use old parts, build
useful things and come up with
creative solutions to problems.

OTTO

Huh. That sounds a bit confusing to be honest.

BEX

(chuckling)

Okay, yeah I guess so. Basically they want to discover and learn all kinds of things, and encourage others to do so too.

(pause)

They love projects like your gadget.

OTTO

(resigned)

Well that's neat I guess... But not an efficient use of resources and just an indulgence.

BEX

(offended)

No it isn't! This is how society moves forward and how improvements and innovation are created!

OTTO

(irritated)

If you say so. But I guess I need to get back to work now.

BEX

(stiffly)

I see. Yes, I better let you get back to the grind.

Bex moves to the door and waves goodbye to Otto. Otto nods and waves at him as they leave.

INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

The office at noon.

Otto is looking at his gadget, lost in thought. Otto looks from the gadget, to the box of production malfunctions, then to the door. And back again. And again. He lets out a deep sigh. Otto takes the gadget, opens the compartment in his chest and puts the gadget inside, before closing it again. Otto gets up and leaves the room.

INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

//View out of the window//

Otto is moving swiftly across the car park in front of the production hall, towards the gated entrance of the Factory grounds.

EXT. FACTORY GROUNDS / PARKING LOT - DAY

Otto moves cautiously past the parking lot with Bex's van on it, towards the gate in the fence that goes all around the Factory grounds.

Approaching the gate, he looks around to see if anyone is watching, and very slowly tries to open the door inside the gate. As soon as Otto pushes down the door handle, flashing lights blare up and a piercing ALARM sounds.

Utterly shocked, Otto freezes for a few seconds, before racing away from the gate. He speeds back towards the Factory office building.

Vague outlines of guards approach the gate in the distance.

INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

Otto rushes into his office and slams the door shut. Trying to calm himself, he looks out the window before taking a seat at his desk. Having calmed a little, Otto takes out the gadget from the compartment in his chest and looks at it.

Suddenly, with a loud BANG, Typeface slams open the door of the room and barges into Otto's office.

TYPEFACE

(shouting angrily)

YOU! I know it was you! The cameras caught you! And your chip tried to connect with the gate! This severely crosses the line! Are you forgetting what you are?! How dare you further waste time and money instead of working on this week's report?!

Typeface notices the gadget in Otto's hands.

TYPEFACE (CONT'D)

(absolutely enraged)

This thing again! I have had enough!
This will have consequences! Your chip ought to be removed!

Typeface rips the gadget out of Otto's hands and catapults it into the trashcan standing next to Otto's desk. Typeface then rushes out of the room, leaving a severely shocked Otto sitting at his desk like a frozen statue, with wide-open eyes and mouth, staring at the place where Typeface had stood.

After a minute, Otto regains some of his composure. He looks down at the chip implanted on his chest, then at the door. Slowly moving towards the door, he bends over and picks the gadget back out from the trashcan. Otto gently dusts it off, looks at it and places it into his chassis again.

OTTO
(muttering to himself)
I guess 'waste of resources' depends
on how you look at it...

After a moment of contemplation, Otto moves towards the door and leaves the room.

INT. OTTO'S OFFICE - DAY

//View out of the window//

In the distance, Otto carefully looks around before hurrying across the parking lot towards Bex's van.

EXT. FACTORY GROUNDS / PARKING LOT - DAY

An empty parking lot with just Bex's van still parked in front of the Factory production hall.

INT. VAN - DAY

Inside the back of the van, Otto sits in the furthest corner, as small as he can possibly make himself, hiding behind toolboxes.

Suddenly the back door opens as Bex loads tools and broken remains of Factory hardware into the van. Bex sees Otto, pauses and stares at him for a second. Otto nervously gestures to Bex to keep quiet. After a split second Bex nods and winks at Otto, before proceeding to load up the van as if there was nothing out of the ordinary, and closes the door again.

EXT. FORREST ROAD - DA

A road next to a large forest.

Bex drives the van along the road before pulling over next to a forest.

Bex gets out and walks around to the back, opening it and waiting for Otto to emerge. Once they're standing next to each other, Bex addresses Otto, who is visibly nervous.

BEX

Had a change of heart, eh? Well, I'm happy to see it. It won't be easy, let me tell you that. Re-adjusting. Leaving old ways behind.

Otto looks uncertain.

OTTO

What do I do now? I'd love to meet the people you mentioned, but is that even possible? ... What a stupid idea.

BEX

I don't think it's a stupid idea. You have the same background as me, I can see how I would be unhappy working in the Factory, instead of coming up with creative ideas and building things that actually could serve more purposes.

OTTO

(surprised)

That's a good way of putting it. That's exactly it!

BEX

But the HACKER SPACE won't just let anyone in. There is a risk involved for them to be found out. 9

OTTO

(nervous)

What do you mean?

BEX

The Factory hates the open source approach, people able to understand and fix their own tech. And they're always looking for information that could help shut the HACKER SPACE down. How do we know you're serious and not leaking intel?

Otto thinks for a minute.

OTTO

I will remove my chip.

BEX

(slightly surprised)

You know what that means? If you're found by the Factory or any authorities looking for you, they will assume you're malfunctioning? A robot without a chip? They'll recycle you? Completely? Robot-death?

OTTO

(with a huff)

You don't have your chip anymore.

BEX

Yeah, but I don't work for them. They don't care much in that case usually. You, however, ran away.

Otto firmly looks at Bex. While maintaining eye contact, he starts to try to pull the chip off his chassis. It ends up being a lot more firmly implanted than Otto had anticipated and doesn't budge.

Bex silently looks on, as Otto opens the cabinet in his chassis, rummages around and pulls out a screwdriver. Using it, Otto proceeds to remove his chip. After eventually managing to remove it, Otto holds it out to Bex. After a moment of silence where both look at the chip in Otto's hand, Otto looks up at Bex.

BEX (CONT'D)

Yep, guess you're serious about it. Good. The HACKER SPACE is not too far from here.

Otto looks at Bex nervously.

BEX (CONT'D)

Give it a try. (with a smile) You'll see.

OTTO

Where do I go?

BEX

(pointing towards a footpath into the forest)

See this path? Follow it and eventually you'll come across a forest clearing. It's a bit hidden, but you'll find it.

Otto, still looking nervous turns around and faces the path. He takes a deep breath to steady himself.

BEX (CONT'D)
I'll be seeing you!

Otto turns his head, nods and gives Bex a quick smile.

OTTO
Thank you.

At this, Otto turns and starts to walk down the path into the forest.

EXT. FOREST - DAY

Walking through the forest, Otto's head keeps on turning from side to side, up and down, trying to take everything in. He starts to smile whilst looking at the plants, pausing here and there to study flora and fauna more closely.

As he continues deeper into the forest, once in a while odd looking tech gadgets appear. Little cases are attached to occasional trees. Some are dug into the ground. Some are next to small boards with animal feed on it.

Otto leaves the path to inspect the next gadget he comes across. It's a small wildlife camera with a squirrel-feeder on a tree. Curious, Otto picks up one of the crumbs lying on it and inspects it closely, as he returns to the path again.

Continuing onward, another tech-gadget appears, this one stuck into the ground next to a wilted plant. Its display reads Watering level below min. threshold. As Otto is pondering about the gadget, a squirrel pops up behind a tree, noticing the crumb in Otto's hand. When Otto notices the squirrel, he is startled.

The squirrel continues to sit there, its eyes flickering between Otto, and the crumb in his hand. After a few seconds Otto realizes what the squirrel is looking at, and slowly moves his hand with the crumb towards the squirrel. In response the squirrel twitches its ears. Otto stretches his hand out further.

Suddenly, lightning-fast, the squirrel runs forward, jumps onto OTTO's hand, takes the crumb. It races back to its previous position next to the tree, where the squirrel consumes it, whilst watching Otto cautiously. Otto begins to grin, and watches the squirrel eat. Then, happily swinging his arms as he moves along, Otto turns back towards the path and continues on his journey.

EXT. FOREST CLEARING - DAY

Walking down the path, eventually Otto notices light falling through trees on the left of the path.

He leaves the path to investigate it and notices a trampled footpath leading through the trees.

Otto follows it and reaches a forest clearing. A red-painted wooden windswept hut is standing in the middle of the clearing. It has solar panels on the roof and an air-borne wind-turbine floating above it in the sky.

The view of this curious looking building causes Otto to approach it with awe, coming closer and trying to take it all in, looking at the tools and tech gadgets set up around the house, in raised flowerbeds and all.

As he gets closer to the building, the door opens. KATIE, the lead hacker of the group, appears in the doorway. With a grin she noticed Otto's cautious curiosity.

Katie pauses for a second, before gesturing for Otto to come closer, which he slowly does.

KATIE

(bemused)

Sorry, for a second there I thought you were someone else, who looks almost identical.

OTTO

(nervous)

Oh that's quite alright. Actually, it was Bex who suggested I come by here.

KATIE

(kindly)

Oh, neat! So you're one of Bex's. I haven't heard from them yet about how it went. How'd you end up here?

Noticing Ottos's hesitation, Katie steps out of the doorway towards Otto.

OTTO

I was working in the Factory.

Katie noticeably stiffens up at hearing this.

OTTO (CONT'D)

(con't)

But came to realize I had to get away.

KATIE

How do I know you're not a spy?

Otto shows her the removed chip and points at the freshly empty spot on his chassis.

Katie's eyes widen.

OTTO
(quietly)
I... I just couldn't stay any longer.
Just as I was getting desperate,
BEX showed up. They mentioned
something about others who would
understand me.
(his voice trails off)

Katie looks at him sympathetically.

OTTO (CONT'D)
I can't go back, it was unbearable! So
I realized I have no more use for my
chip. And I'd rather end up recycled
than back at that soul-sucking
repetitive place. I want to build,
invent, learn things!

Katie starts to smile upon seeing Otto's enthusiasm.

KATIE:
I guess you're alright. But removing
your chip really was a drastic measure
to take.

OTTO
(with a sigh of relief)
Phew. So...what do you do here?

KATIE
We use old or broken or discarded
materials to build new creations, or
try out new experiments to find
creative solutions to existing
problems

Upon hearing this, Otto gets over his shyness. He takes out his
gadget from the small compartment in his chest, and shows it to
Katie.

KATIE (CONT'D)
Wow! This is very cool. Looks like a
great project start. Any idea yet what
you want to do with it?

Otto shakes his head.

KATIE (CONT'D)
Do you want to take a look inside? You
could continue working on your project
here if you'd like.

Excited, Otto nods and together they walk into the HACKER SPACE.

INT. HACKER SPACE - DAY

Inside the HACKER SPACE is a spacious room. It is warmly lit by sunshine through the windows and fairy lights strung along the wooden walls. The walls are clad with pegboards and covered with posters and stickers. Along the walls stand various types of work benches. The work benches include all kinds of tools and saws, 3D printers and screwdrivers. In the far corner is a collection of beanbags, hammocks, plants and bookshelves.

Katie shows Otto the different parts of the space and the workstations, before eventually reaching for the bookshelf and holding a book out to Otto titled Circuit Bending.

KATIE

(gently)

Here. This might be of interest to you, if you want to look into how to set up your own systems, now that you have removed the chip. It looks scarier than it is.

Otto looks at her, then takes the book.

OTTO

Thank you... How did you come to work here?

Katie takes a moment and looks at her left hand, before removing the glove she's wearing on it.

KATIE

As a child I was in an accident where I lost my hand. Robo-prosthetics were already a thing. But after some years, the Factory didn't want to continue the updates. Instead we should buy new and more expensive models. Ridiculous.

Otto stares at her with big eyes, then looks at her hand. Katie holds it up a bit so Otto can see it better.

KATIE (CONT'D)

There was no way I'd let them bully me into it. So I started learning and experimenting until I had hacked every last part of it... took some time though. I wished there was someplace where I could have gone and asked for help.

OTTO

(shy)

I'm sorry. I didn't mean to be rude,
asking such a personal question.

KATIE

(laughs)

That's alright. Anyway. That's how I
came to open this place.

Otto looks at the pieces of tech and tools strewn across the
room, then out the window, once again with a fascinated look.

KATIE (CONT'D)

Speaking of which, I still need to
finish building a case. How about you
continue working on your project a
bit?

Otto is overjoyed at hearing this. Taking the book Katie gave
him, and his gadget, Otto settles at a workbench with a
soldering iron on it and start tinkering. Katie leaves for work.

MACHINERY can be heard to start up and work-in-progress NOISES
from woodworking can be heard.

INT. HACKER SPACE - NIGHT

Later in the evening, Katie comes over to Otto's workbench. Otto
looks over his shoulder as she approaches, leaning to the side
so that Katie can see what he's been working on. She nods
approvingly. Happy, Otto shows Katie his revised gadget.

OTTO

(happy and nervous)

Look! I hope it works.

He leads Katie towards the plant-shelf at the window in the
corner of the room, to one of the berry-bearing plants. Three
finger-like parts of the gadget reach out and gently pull one of
the ripe berries off the plant without breaking it and holds it
softly.

KATIE

(happy)

Well done! Such delicate handling!
I've been trying to fine-tune
something like that for ages! I wish
we had more people around here with
your skills.

OTTO
(surprised)
Really?

KATIE
Yes! I'm desperately looking for more help with courses for people who come here and want to learn more, but often I simply don't have enough time to support everyone.

OTTO
(his eyes widening)
If...if that is something I could do, I'd love to! I mean, if I can stay here?

KATIE
(laughing)
That can be arranged! There's a spare room out back that you could stay in, and enough power from our off-grid supply that you can use to charge yourself up.

Otto looks around as if seeing the place again for the first time and breaks into a big smile.

INT. HACKER SPACE - NIGHT

Later in the night, Otto is cozily sitting in the beanbag in the corner of the room, plugged into a power outlet, recharging. He looks across the workspaces and shelves with a huge and sleepy smile on his face.

Otto lets out a deep breath of relief and comfort, stretches and yawns and closes his eyes, smiling and drifting off into sleep.

FADE TO BLACK.

CREDITS